
Review

Sober and institutional. A serif body pushed right off a working left rail that carries sources, figure topics and the folio.

Use it for: evidence reports, research reviews, state-of-the-field documents.

01

What a Style Actually Is

A template style is a grid, a palette, a set of page furniture and a type pairing, decided together. Change one of them alone and you have not made a variant — you have made an inconsistency.

Three well-typeset reports read page by page turn out to disagree about almost every choice a template makes. One justifies its text and two set it ragged. One uses three type families, one uses two, and one uses barely more than one. One works its wide margin hard, one explains it and one simply commits to leaving it empty.

What they share is not a choice at all. Each has decided what its pages say about themselves — where the folio sits, what the running foot carries, how a figure is captioned and sourced — and then repeated that decision without variation across between forty-six and ninety-six pages. The professional look is the consistency.

The rail is the Review style's signature: it exists so that a source credit never has to interrupt a sentence.

The practical test when adding anything to a template: does this element appear on at least ten pages, in exactly the same place, doing exactly the same job? If not, it is decoration, and it will cheapen the pages that do not have it.

— docs/report-design-principles.md, principle 10

This is why a comparison that varies only the typeface answers the wrong question. Set the same paragraph in four faces and the differences are real but small, and none of them is the difference between a document that reads as designed and one that does not.

What varies between these three pages

- the grid — where the text column sits and what, if anything, works the margin
- the palette, and how many jobs colour is asked to do
- the page furniture: masthead, rail, folio, running foot, colophon
- the type pairing, which is the part a font specimen would have shown on its own

Essay

Literary and warm. A display serif over a reading serif on warm paper, generous margins, and an accent used only on rules and numerals.

Use it for: long-form argument, essays, book chapters, thought pieces.

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Brief

Direct and sans-forward. A short measure
hard left, a worked right rail, boxed key
messages and a colophon that identifies any
single sheet.

Use it for: position papers, policy briefs, submissions.

A. What a Style Actually Is

IN BRIEF

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The professional look is the consistency, not the choices.

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10

pages an element must appear on to earn its place

PRINCIPLE 10

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